The Family Care Snapshot Checklist

The people, routines and information to write down while Mom is doing fine.

Mom is doing fine, mostly, and nothing has happened. This is a list of what to ask about, list and write down so the family has one picture of how her week works today. You have time, so it can be done over a few ordinary visits. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something for another visit, not a verdict about Mom or about anyone who helps her.

Ask

- [ ] Ask Mom to walk you through an ordinary week, in her own words, before anyone describes it for her.
- [ ] Ask about each part of her day: mornings, daytime, evenings and overnight.
- [ ] Ask the person who does the most for her which of their jobs are getting harder to keep up.
- [ ] Ask Mom whether she's happy for the family to gather the notes that already exist, such as what was written down at an appointment.

List

- [ ] Where Mom lives, and who is in the house or close by.
- [ ] Everyone who helps her, including the small things: the sister who drives her to appointments, the neighbor who brings in the mail.
- [ ] What each person actually does, and how often. [2]
- [ ] Family members, neighbors and the professionals she already sees, with a phone number for each. [1]

Write

- [ ] Three separate lists: what you know for certain, what someone in the family has noticed, and what nobody knows yet.
- [ ] How each relative describes her week, side by side, with the differences left in.
- [ ] What Mom corrects when you read the page back to her, where possible, and what the family adds after.
- [ ] When the family will look at the page again.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you ask, list and write down. It doesn't say how Mom is managing, or whether the help around her is the right amount. A checklist can't tell you that, and this one doesn't try.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked, listed and written down how Mom's week works today. The care interview goes through her situation area by area, including the parts no one in the family has thought to mention, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The item marked 1 follows AARP's Prepare to Care guide, and the item marked 2 follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's Caregiving 101. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver